Week 4: Interviewing Potential Customers

There are three over-arching questions you want to get answers to when interviewing potential customers:

1. Why is there a problem?
2. What is the cause of this problem?
3. What is the customer's imagined solution?

Tips to successful interviewing:

- Take good notes.
- Be open to customers correcting your assumptions.
- This is a qualitative and not quantitative interview. In other words, you do not simply tally the number of answers to find that nine out of 10 said one thing. There might be value in why one out of 10 said something different.
- Share your thoughts and ideas (but don't sell).
- Ask open-ended questions.

Instead of...	**Ask...**
How much would you pay?	Talk me through the last time you had a problem with …
Do you like my idea?	How much grief, time, effort is this problem causing you?
Would you buy this product?	Show me how you currently solve (or attempt to solve this problem).
	Who else should I talk to learn more about this problem?

Collecting useful data is difficult. Here are some signs that you have failed in your efforts to find out about the customer and that the customer instead thinks you are attempting to sell to them:

- "I love it."
- "Brilliant idea."
- "Let me know when you launch."

The above statements are signs you have a false positive. i.e., the person is indicating that your product or service will solve their problem when in fact they don't have the problem you think you are solving. You know this because they aren't talking about it, they're only talking about how great your idea is.

The Problem

You want to be able to describe the things (what) the customer is trying to get done or overcome in the customer's own words.

Types of questions to ask your customer about the problem:

- Can you explain why this problem exists?
- What are your needs that you are having a hard time satisfying?
- Can you show me/explain the ways that you currently solve this problem?
- How do you imagine (describe your solution) solving the problem?

The Issues

You want to be able to describe the shortcomings/pains that your customers are currently having with other solutions in their words. This can include bad outcomes (low sales, lack of customers, low quality). This should help you identify the obstacles that they are facing with current solutions.

Types of questions to ask your customer about the issues:

- Talk me through the frustrations, annoyances that keep you up at night/give you headaches?
- In what areas are your current solutions underperforming?
- What is the most common mistake you encounter when attempting to solve the problem?
- What about the current solution is most and least satisfying?

Success

You want to be able to describe the outcomes that the customer believes that they want to achieve. This should be positioned as concrete as possible.

Types of questions to ask your customer about potential success:

- What would make you happy as a customer?
- What is your current level of expected quality?
- What would make your life/work easier?
- What impact are you trying to achieve (social, economic)?
- What do you aspire to achieve; how do you measure success?
- Talk me through your imagined solution to this problem.

After you have completed the interviews write up the key ideas on post-it notes. Sort the data by the three topics:

1. Problems they were attempting to solve;
2. Issues with other solutions; and
3. How successful your solution was in solving their problems.

Do this after each interview. After you have completed the interviews, reflect on all the data and begin sorting and ranking the data by importance.

Tips to avoid common mistakes when interviewing customers:

You need to try to clearly differentiate the **Problem, Issue,** and **Success.** This requires an explicit effort to separate the problem they face with the other potential solutions for doing that job (attaining a desired outcome). If you can discover how the customer measures the problem, then you can find solutions based on their understanding of the issues in attempting to solve that problem.

Common mistakes to avoid:

- Mixing customer segments
- Mixing problem and success
- Being too generic
- Not completely setting aside your assumptions
- Not actively listening
- Not using follow-up questions and missing an opportunity to expand customer understanding
- Not setting enough time aside to allow for a good interview
- Not preparing and practicing questions for customer interviews